

I KNEW YOU EXISTED



ANTOAN KURTI : APPLICATION

FOR KOSOVAR PROJECTS FOR MANIFESTA14 PRISHTINA 2022

I knew you existed

The trigger point

A few years ago, a 16-year-old Kosovar man, whom I met on a dating app, shared with me an experience: while he was going to a motel with a barely adult man, he and his partner were arrested by the police. The two officers threatened them with a fine *unless* the young men let them join, and gave them sexual favors - which they accepted.

This testimony made me wonder. On the attitude of the two police officers, first. How, in an environment that condemns homosexuality, did officers in service dare to take this risk? How predictable was the reaction of the young boys? I wondered about their mores too: were the policemen openly gay, to each other? Did they usually have sex together? Were they a couple?

Then, it was the attitude of my interlocutor that challenged me. Although the experience appears to be traumatic (and legally falls under the abuse of a minor), he told it to me with a certain distance, saying that he had enjoyed it. But, for this young adult, what might be the psychological and emotional implications of this event in the long term?

And above all: if this young homosexual boy had wanted to file a complaint for police and sexual violence (the law enforcement representatives imposed insertive anal penetrations, by the three adults, on the minor), what would have been his chances of being listened to, in a homophobic and dysfunctional system?

The process

Through photographic portraits¹, video interviews and audio recordings, I want to collect the testimonies of LGBTQIA+ people invisibilized by the Kosovar society. The objective is to show their existence, and thereby participate in the improvement of their living conditions, by raising awareness of the daily violence they are subjected to.

I want to enable them tell their stories². What LGBTQIA+ people experience and how they experience it. But also what would allow them to live better, and to feel full members of Kosovar society. These personal stories make a history that combines what is unique to each person and what brings them together. Each singular experience contributes to a common fresco on what it means to be queer, in Prishtina, in the 2020s.

¹ I work with analog photography.

² LGBTQIA+ archives and history are almost inexistant in Kosovo and all of the Balkans.

A global view

This work carried out for Manifesta will be part of a global approach: my ambition is to document the contemporary reality of LGBTQIA+ people in different cities, despite borders.

A first part of this research has already been carried out in São Paulo (to be consulted in the Links section) - it is, moreover, the inscription "*Eu sabia que você existia*" seen in giant characters on a building of the megalopolis, that gave the name to the project.

I wish to extend this research to other cities, such as Tunis, Marseilles, Tirana, Tbilisi, Tangier, Athens, Istanbul, Kiev, Bogota... in order to highlight the particularities of individual experiences, and their pressure with the history of the premises.

References :

Larry Clark • Édouard Louis • Hervé Guibert • Ryan McGinley • Antonio Da Silva • Spyros Rennt • Florian Hetz • Rosie Matheson • Lou Escobar • Wolfgang Tillmans • Bruce LaBruce • Dan Flavin • Crawford Barton • Kostis Fokas • Brooke DiDonato

The device

The installation “I knew you existed” takes the form of a labyrinth. It invites the viewers to a visit similar to a walk. As they wander around, the visitors discover new elements. An experience also similar to scrolling on social networks. Put end to end, the set of information (still images, videos, sound recordings) allow the visitor to come out of there like a close confidant.

The darkened room of 12m x 20m and only lit by infrared lights, offers a total sensory experience, mixing darkness and warmth reminiscent of the dark rooms³ of cruising⁴ bars.

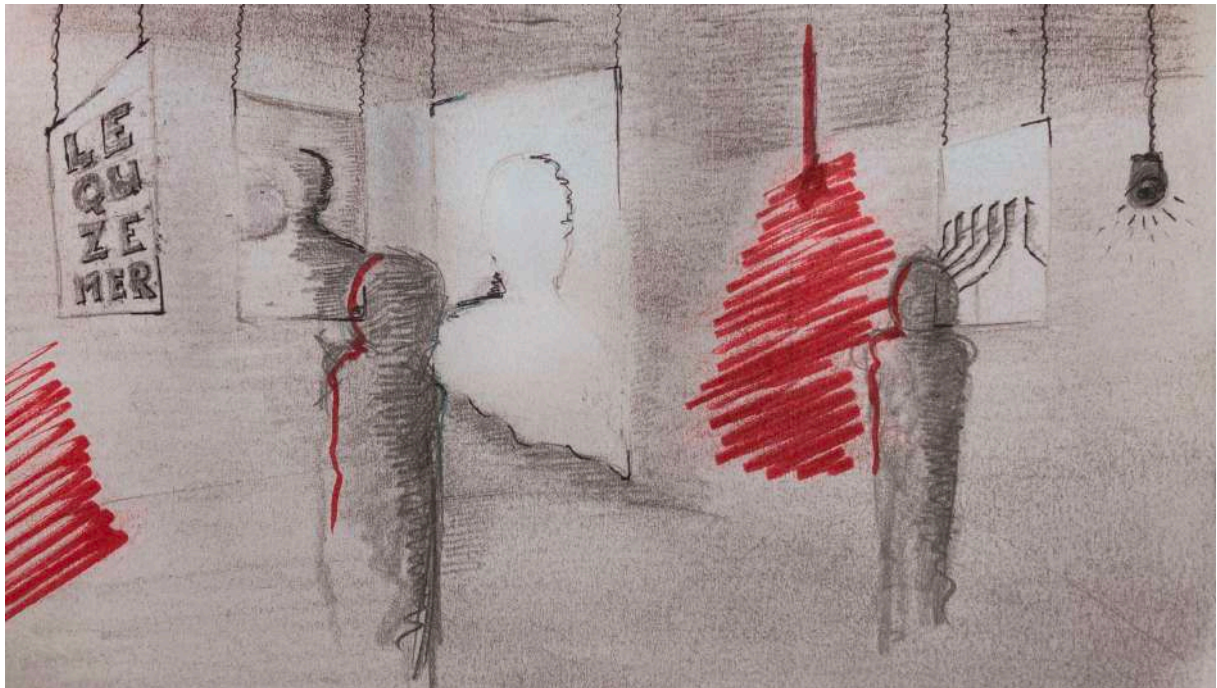
It includes :

- Two projections (on translucent canvas of 90 x 160 cm - in portrait mode) of different testimonies of LGBTQIA+ people in relation to their living conditions,
- Four photographs (90 x 160 cm, archival pigment prints - 3mm dibond) :
 - photographic portraits of LGBTQIA+ people and
 - portraits of the city (with potential cruising spots and safe places where LGBTQIA+ can go out),
- Three audio recordings that will contain whispered and intense stories in terms of secrecy and mores,
- Two posters (240gr matte poster paper) which will contain texts of a militant nature,
- Four infrared lights.

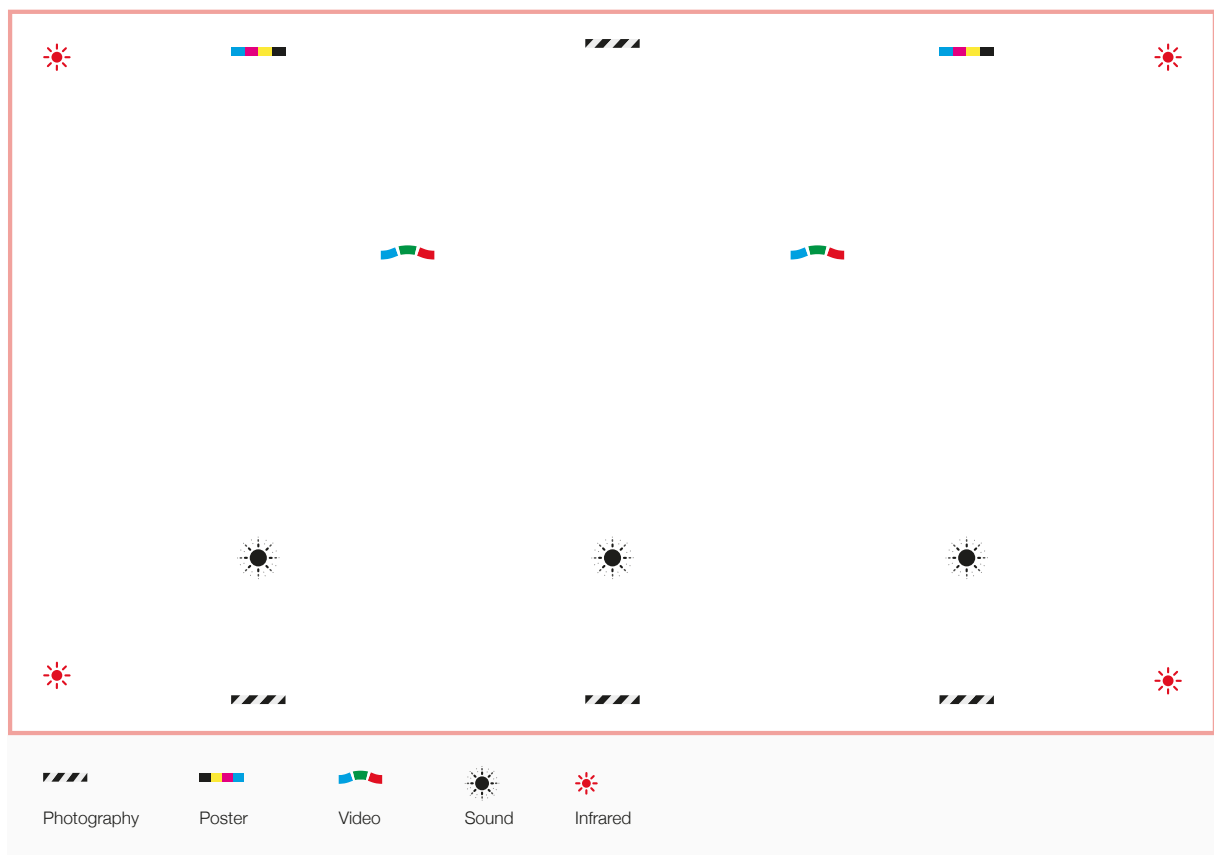
³ A room, often shaped as a labyrinth and lit with discrete lights or no lights at all, in a gay bar, gay sauna or adult movie theaters, where a customer can engage in sexual activity.

⁴ Aimlessly wandering in the search of an anonymous partner for gay sex. Cruising can be practiced in dark rooms or outdoors in specific cruising areas.

Sketch :

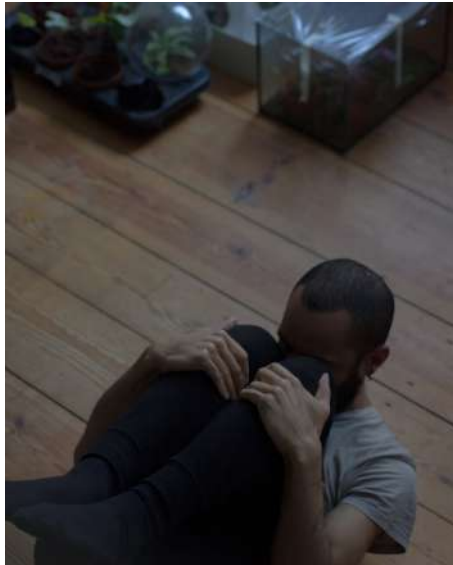


Sketch that illustrates the mood.



The disposal of the different elements in a space of 12 m x 20 m.

Images / portfolio :





Estimated budget :

Budget for exhibition : I knew you existed

	Quantity	Price
Photography	4	1705,2
Video projectors	2	930
Sound speakers	3	150
Posters	2	863,94
Infrared Lights	4	200
Transport (to Kosovo & back)	1	1000
Unexpected costs		150,86
Total		5000

Note :

This provisional budget may potentially vary depending on the elements that materialize over time. Location will be a major factor. The installation is at this stage modular.

I am also in talks with the LGBTQIA+ associations in Prishtina, CEL Kosova and CSGD, to find additional funding.

In addition to Kosovar organizations, I will extend my search for funding to Belgian LGBTQIA+ associations.

Bio :

I was born in Kosovo which I had to flee with my sisters during the war when I was still a teenager. I arrived in Belgium, without papers, with a cultural shift that marked my history and generated a search for identity. This has fueled my entire personal and professional journey. I have always had a strong need to question identity through my artistic approach and in the different environments in which I have evolved. I worked for a while in special effects for film and advertising. This universe where all images are faked and devoid of truth has reinforced my quest for identity.

My life experience and the rise of social media (the culture of influence and the ephemeral) led me to want to document the world as real as possible through photography and video. That's why I mostly work on film photography.

CV :

3 MAY 2019

INTERSECTIONNALITÉ

MAISON ARC-EN-CIEL / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

4 MAY 2018

ON N'A PAS TOUS LES JOURS 20 ANS

MAISON ARC-EN-CIEL / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

11 FEBRUARY 2017

ALL JOY WANTS ETERNITY

TULLA / TIRANA, ALBANIA

09 NOVEMBER 2013

I WAS IN KOSOVODUPLEX 100M2 GALLERY / SARAJEVO,
BOSNIA & HERZEGOVINA

13 SEPTEMBER 2013

**ALONE TOGETHER:
PHOTOGRAPHY AND THE OTHER**GJON MILI - GALERIA E ARTEVE / PRISHTINA,
KOSOVO

AUGUST 2013

YOUTH AND SOCIETY

HAMAM - DOKUFEST / PRIZREN, KOSOVO

11 OCTOBER 2012

CHIC & CHEAP

GALERIE INTRAMUROS / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

SEPTEMBER 2009

JACQUES LIZÈNE, RÉTROSPECTIVEGALERIE DE L'ACADÉMIE DES BEAUX ARTS /
LIÈGE, BELGIUM

11 JUNE 2009

VOUS ÊTES DES ANIMAUXMAMAC - MUSÉE DE L'ART MODERNE ET DE
L'ART CONTEMPORAIN / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

9 MAY 2008

ANTOAN KURTI PEINTURES

REFRESH / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

1 MARCH 2007

5

SOUNDSTATION GALLERY / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

APRIL 2005

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L'ESCALIER / LIÈGE, BELGIUM

Links :

Personal website : antoankurti.com

Work in progress « I knew you existed » construction of the website with content from São Paulo : queer21.antoankurti.com

Instagram profile : [@antoankurti](https://www.instagram.com/antoankurti)

Other links : linktr.ee/antoankurti